



Linnæus University

Sweden

Bachelor's Thesis

Sticks and Idiots

Dummy-Problem Metadesign Workshop

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The Apollo 11 moon landing in 1969 famously exhibits the moment when commander Neil Armstrong and lunar module pilot Buzz Aldrin have transported a lucky Stick to the moon. As the atmosphere on the moon cannot blow wind that would uphold the American flag properly, this Stick was attached perpendicular to the flag pole on the top side of it to support the flag. The Stick was explicitly designed for that purpose. It was thought of, designed, prototyped and manufactured on Earth, to be later transported on a spaceship trip to the moon and ultimately left there as it pursues its value. Would it be a stupid question to ask: what is the value of the Stick then?

The Stick was conceptually made, moved and set on the moon before the mission. If that is how one Stick is moved, let me ask another stupid question: how do we move other Sticks?



Apollo 11 Moon Landing, 1969
Source: pixabay.com

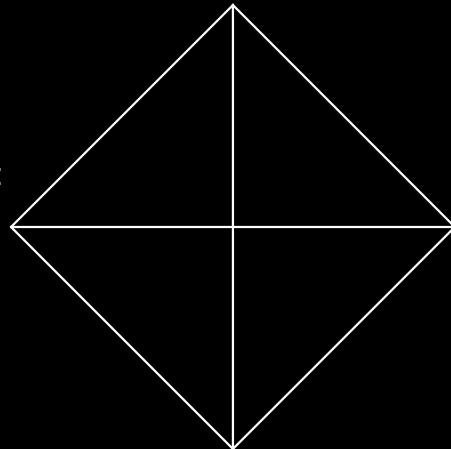
I bring this example to help you picture my intention with this project. From the position of a design student and discoursing design sustainability, I hope to inspire designers to ask the most stupid yet potentially challenging questions to answer.

The complexity of the responses may reflect the less explored problems that the design industry generates. Shifting between local and global levels through metadesign means enables us to illustrate the merging dynamics that design decisions have on life quality and the environment. As far as the ethical implications of mine and the participants' design decisions, I consider the format of the workshop and the setup of Stick-Moving to be intrinsically ethical. Thus, I refrain from asking 'how can we move a stick ethically?' but rather leave it to 'how can we move a Stick?'



UNETHICAL DESIGNS DONE BY DESIGNERS
MORE OR LESS AWARE OF THE IMPACT OF
THEIR DESIGN DECISIONS

DESIGN STUDENT:
0. IDIOT
-1. STICK



DESIGN TEAMS:
1. DESIGN AND POSTHUMANISM
2. FRIEND GROUP
3. VRÅNGSHOLMEN

METADESIGN AWARENESS WORKSHOP
WITH QUESTIONING AS BASE METHOD

Wood, J. (2005)

The Tetrahedron can Encourage Designers to Formalise More Responsible Strategies.
Journal of Art, Design & Communication, 3(3)

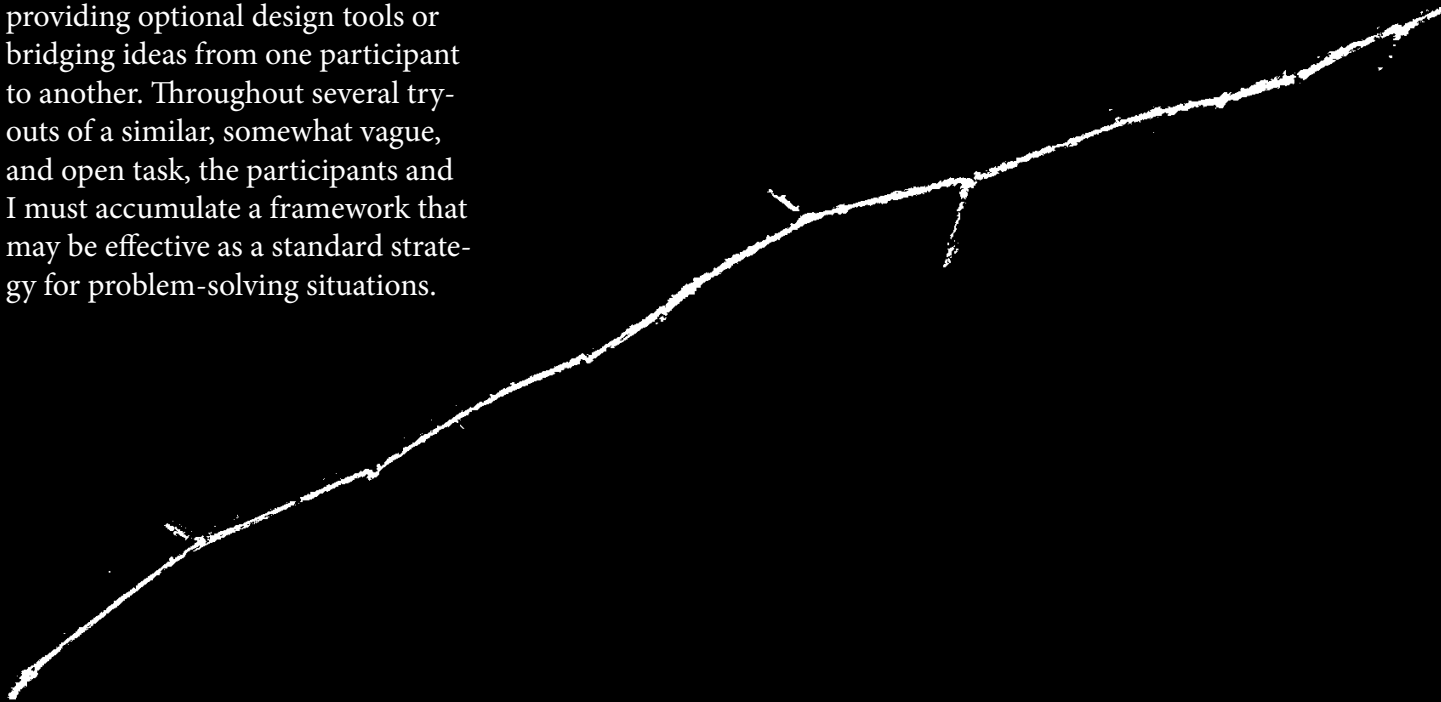


RESEARCH QUESTION:
HOW CAN WE USE METADESIGN TO DEVELOP A METHOD
FOR APPROACHING META-DESIGN EASILY?

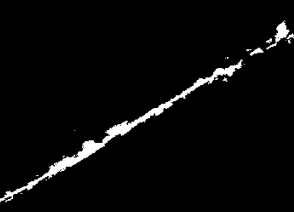
Abstract

This project involves forming and executing several differently structured metadesign workshops to capture effective methods that could apply in standard creative scenarios. I approach these workshops through a participatory design lens by flattening the hierarchy between the participants and me, the designer. My role is to host and guide workshops while providing optional design tools or bridging ideas from one participant to another. Throughout several try-outs of a similar, somewhat vague, and open task, the participants and I must accumulate a framework that may be effective as a standard strategy for problem-solving situations.

The question that I propose is “how can we move a Stick?”. It is worth assuming that moving this stick by myself would be redundant and stranded from influence and criticism, therefore against the principles of the project.



The Stick



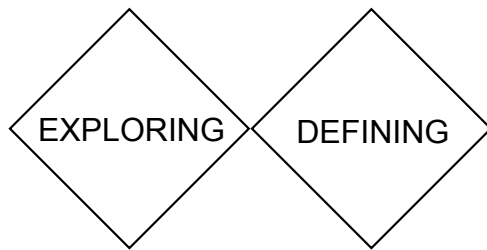
I want to mention the origin of my motivation and the nature of my new design theory perspectives. First and foremost, the seed of the stick idea is none other than a personal crisis as a change agent. A crisis fed by anger and anxiety related to my lack of agency. The stick is a metaphor of any systematic oppression, that at a very local level, any effort against seems insignificant to many, so easy to take for granted. Having a short design background, as a still-learning student, I have more easily accustomed to this metaphor.

At first I had no idea how to move a stick or motivate others to join and move it together. As I progressed, I was inspired by another piece from Tony Fry, his video titled *Crisis of Crisis Crisis* (2020). He explained thoroughly his opinion on how a lack of an immediate crisis brings us into a state of alienation from our agency. After a few workshops, I managed to determine in shaping a standardized framework applicable for many scenarios. Yet, anger, anxiety, and curiosity played a relevant role as research fuel in my early stages.

If problem + design = solution, we face two unknown elements of the equation: the problem and the solution. Let us replace the problem with a dummy-problem, namely the moving-a-stick metaphor. Now the equation looks like this: stick + design = solution. We will experiment with a fake issue to analyze and criticize designs. The dummy-problem has little potential to become a crisis.

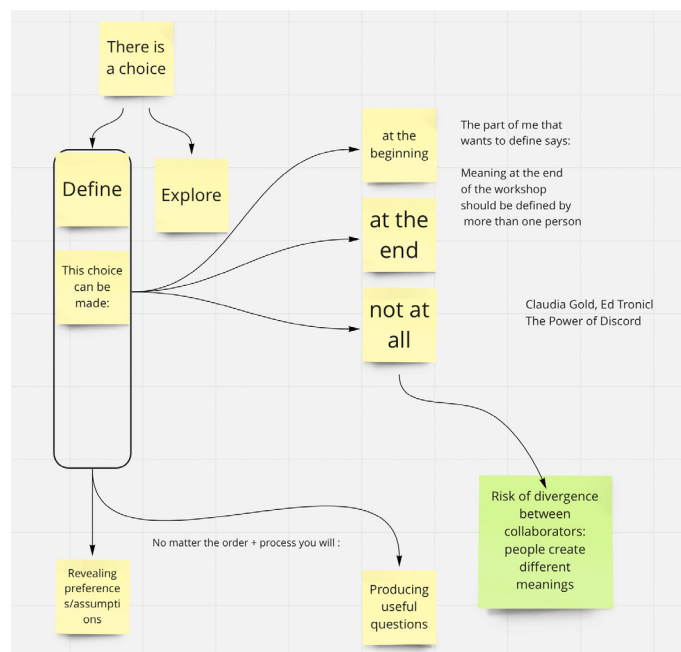
Exploring and Defining

The double diamond diagram is mainly used to represent several linear steps of the design thinking process. The first diamond expands to a particular key point in the design process and later contracts to a more precise project version. After it grows again, allowing another explorative approach to the project, where theories are tested and prototyped. More explicitly, it works by exploring, defining, then exploring and defining again. Exploring goes ahead of defining at all times and never the other way around.



I reached out to Rory Thomson, a Design +Change alumni and invited him in a workshop. He helped me understand the participatory design dynamics one can employ by drawing a diagram. This diagram is the fork between two possible techniques, exploring and defining. By examining the boundaries of a mission, one can collect preferences and assumptions from the participants. At the same time, there is potential for valid questions to emerge. On the other hand, defining the context from the beginning may shield the participants from confusion. If the context is specified towards the end of the workshop, the team has more influence. Lastly, if the boundaries are not determined until the end, participants may have become accustomed to different interpretations of the project.

Double Diamond Diagram



Rory Thomson, Workshop 8
Choice diagram
Miro

I bridge Thomson's diagram to the concept of the double diamond. The first half of the double diamond is reserved for exploration. In my case, I use the lack of structure to dodge rushing to shallow conclusions. As Thomson pointed out, my workshops were, at that moment, fluid conversations. I try to ensure the ethics of my Design by taking time to explore the potential of the conversation itself. I judge this as a metadesign approach to our voices and initial input. What I was looking for with this approach, were the answers to three questions. How do we explain our language and group dynamic before we start solving problems? Is the creative cluster of designers a caring starting point? What issues do we address when the crisis is not evident?

Reading design critic and author Alice Rawsthorn's *Design Attitude*, from 2019, I try to uncover what the participants think of designing. Can one define "how" before realizing "why"? I am inspired to value ethical design decisions by reading *Ruined by Design*, where author Mike Monteiro brings forward designers' lack of an oath. He mentions that doctors and pharmacists have an oath not to harm anyone through their work.

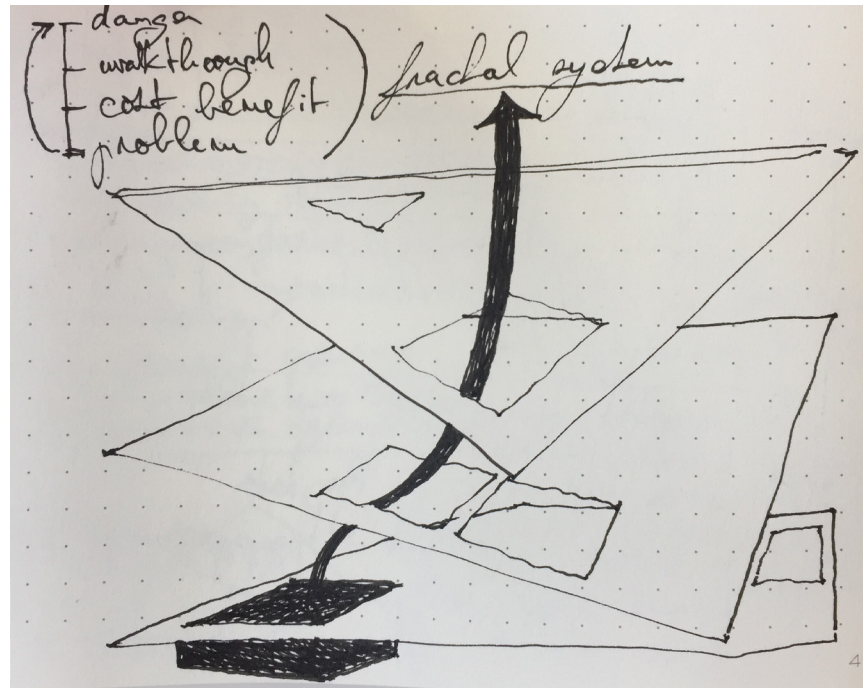
In contrast, designers, which have a tremendous effect on life quality and the environment, do not necessarily create harmless designs. (Mike Monteiro, 2019) Therefore the answer to "why" is always supported by the safety and well-being of humans and other species. When designing in an ethically conscious way, one must understand one's preferences and assumptions. Ethics should be in constant negotiation.

One of the Design +Change aspects of this project stands at its core: slowness. The change that I am mitigating is persuading designers to analyze the design product we use so often that we even forget it is constantly designed. Thinking with Tony Fry, the design product in the cause is the human mind. My plead to designers is to slow down. Familiarize yourself with "how" your mind is designed to design. Accustom yourself to the paradigm that shelters your mind, as it is its designer. Information of any form shapes who we are, how we think, and what we send back into the world. I find it crucial that designers frequently question the structure behind their intentions in the design industry.

Fractal System

During the workshop to which I invited senior scientist Thomas Gkourmpis compared design thinking to fractals. He pictured how one can always magnify detail and uncover several other components of the whole structure. As one ponders, the means of design-thinking may mirror the big picture of the neo-liberal design paradigm. Of course, design decisions at each fractal level may affect other groups. To help me understand, he connects this metaphor to another. He asked me to imagine a game of chess. Moves are made within a cost-benefit framework. He emphasizes how my exercise seems to lack a problem, as the cost-benefit framework does not apply in the absence of any.

My workshops function as a fractal. The participant concluded that we moved the Stick by observing the big picture together. Even if we did not move a contextual or even conceptual Stick, we articulated the means of design-thinking. We moved a bit of every Stick from every workshop that applies the Stick-Moving framework.



Georgian Turturica
"Chess game"
Sketch

Let us compare the fractal to a game of chess. The game has a vast number of possible moves, about 35^{80} (or 10^{123}), aka the “Shannon number.” Yet we play one decision at a time. Each action opens several other potential strategies, some of which generate more advantages than others. Conclusively, some decisions may as well cost us a chess piece, two, three, or even losing the game. The game of chess revolves around the concept of cost-benefit decisions.

Design theory may as well foster the cost-benefit idea. Designers are accustomed to certain “moves” or skill sets like chess pieces. Designers can render change from any position while charged with adequate competence, just as each chess piece impacts the game. If we read a player’s chess pieces as a design team, we can observe how the most beneficial strategies are supported by how designers are conscious of each other and work together. Thinking of chess pieces separately from the rest is ignorant and, to a certain extent, unrealistic. The game is not about one chess piece in particular but the strategy and dynamics behind its usage in rapport with others. Collaboration and participation are elementary for ethical and valuable design decisions.

Idiot Manifesto

I try to profit off my lack of expertise by humbly reinforcing my “idiot” condition. It may be debatable that design research is usually done by non-professionals, but not necessarily designers who may blatantly label themselves as idiots. It may be too late for some experienced designers to come forward with their lack of opportunity or momentum. Yet, I am curious to explore and analyze my current situation to see what I can shape with it. Philosophy scientist Isabelle Stengers dives deeply into sculpting the character of the Idiot and their counterpart in *The Cosmopolitan Proposal* (2004) by stating that a more knowledgeable agent would “obey the nature to be able to control it.” While the Idiot would often doubt the decisions and slow the process by deriving the group’s concentration towards ideas they neither propose nor object. Putting myself in the shoes of the idiot does not restrict my approach entirely. Instead, it helps me expect and channel my lack of knowledge and direction as a design bachelor’s student. By building a genuine collaborative interaction between participants and me, the idiot attributes can even outrage people to the level of expressing their subjective views on the matter.

As Tony Fry emphasizes at the beginning of the 16th chapter of his book, *Design Futuring* (2008), “whether it is employed by self-designated designers or simply by those who use design skills and knowledge - not recognized as such - between other practices, design is all about creativity at its most fundamental.” The reinforcement that Tony Fry brings onto the theory that anyone in different depths and understandings performs Design. Tony Fry also suggests that participatory design in itself can be advanced, primarily through participatory design methods. Therefore, the most pressing question I ask participants right after each workshop is if they can express their criticism towards what we have just done.

Lecturer Marie O'Connor encouraged me to formulate my idiot design role through a manifesto. So I shall give it a try to make myself better understood. The Idiot Manifesto says:

1. I am an idiot.
2. Every group has an idiot. If I am unsure who the idiot is, I am responsible to be the idiot.
3. I am valuable.
4. Yes, there are both stupid and wrong questions and I am glad to voice them.
5. I lack expertise, not empathy.
6. I want to understand, because if I can understand, anyone can.
7. I will slow you down.
8. I will get you lost.
9. I want change.
10. How can we move a stick?

The social sustainability aspect of this project stands in the extrusion from the rigid strategies into a fluid course of analysis. Formality is obsolete in the Idiot's eyes. One of the lines from the Idiot manifesto points out that if the Idiot understands, everyone can; therefore, the Idiot's presence gives inexperienced and unaccustomed participants a place in the frame. Furthermore, once the method is applied, others can be included in the practice as they would be oriented alongside the Idiot. Accordingly, the method is Participatory Design friendly; it does not only serve the specialists but also encourages them to be grounded and inclusive.

The Idiot resides on its consent attribute when it comes to cultural sustainability. I mean consent in that all participants are aware of the Idiot's humble position and presence. The Idiot is expected and also invited to ask questions respectfully. Educating someone regarding one's culture may sometimes be an effort and even frustrating. The Idiot comes with a time frame, a specific amount of questions and an anticipated lack of knowledge. The Idiot's responsibility is to ask, listen and learn. Moving a stick through a cultural lens implies collaboration and, as mentioned before, consent. Again, since the Stick-Moving workshop is Participatory Design friendly, inclusion is necessary. It is not desired that the Stick is moved in the name of another's community, but rather alongside the particularly chosen design team.

Georgian Turturica

"OK."

Quick sketch portraying quite literally the exposed head of the Idiot among experts

Within potential corporate environments, the participants' efforts and time should be monetized for such a practice's resilience. Expecting the working class to participate based on pure agency or citizenship is exploitative. Gatekeeping the projects' profits and institutionalized experience from the participants may result in an economic imbalance among the workers. Yes, answering questions is work, no matter how simple or stupid they are. Credits and income are vital for supporting inclusion and economic balance.

Due to privacy reasons, I will not write about one participant's identity and opinions. Yet, I would go on to how supervisor Åsa Ståhl advised me to process anti-democratic participation during the workshops. One participant brought up conspiracy theories in one of the workshops. At first, I was intrigued and curious about how things could develop. But, looking back at it and with my supervisor's advice in mind, this sort of collaboration could have been a dead end. So, I am searching for pieces that fit the puzzle, as pictured before, through the fractal metaphor.

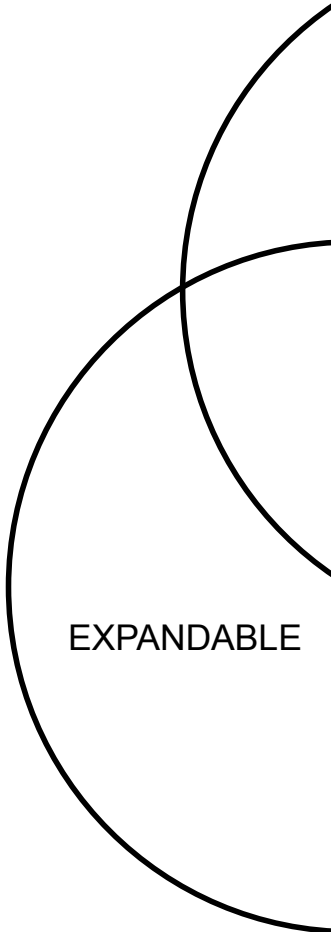


Object Classification, Semantics, and Value

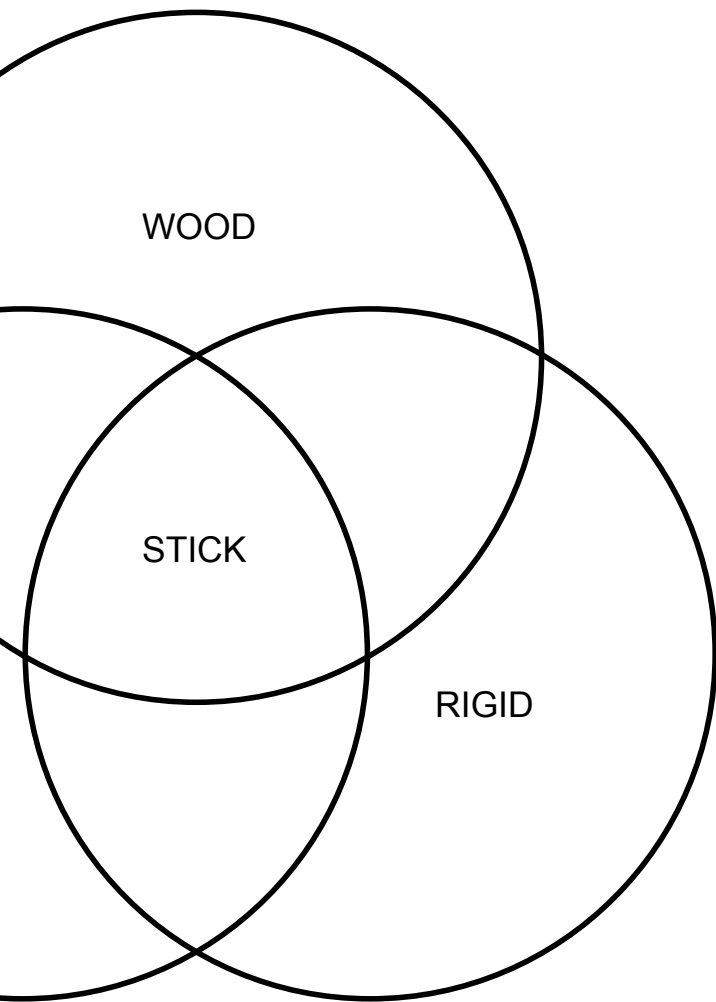
“It is human nature to make classifications,” says Yana Deliyska, Design +Change alumni. Deliyska participated in my first workshop try-out alongside Product Designer Giacomo Tagnin. We channeled our interest in identifying the Stick’s nature through semantics and shared assumptions. We used languaging, brainstorming, show and tell, and interviewing methods. Mostly, we kept the analysis in the paradigm realm, discussing form, function, and the relationship between Sticks and people. For example, when I encouraged them to collect various objects from the apartment that resemble Sticks, we debated which Sticks have more Stick value than others. This was a way of materializing the boundaries of our Stick paradigm. But defining the Stick itself as separate from its replacement is not the primary value to discuss. Instead, as mentioned in the previous part, Cruxes and Comfort, it is the change value that we must determine.

Finally, we intellectualized this data through a Vendite diagram, which supported that the Stick is expandable, made of wood, and rigid enough to transfer force without deforming (mechanical force).

During the interview that followed the workshop, Deliyska advised me to ritualize the workshop and take the role of a place-maker, not only a host. In addition, she made me consider bringing a certain ambiance to the following workshops. Her insights took shape in the workshops described in the next paragraph.



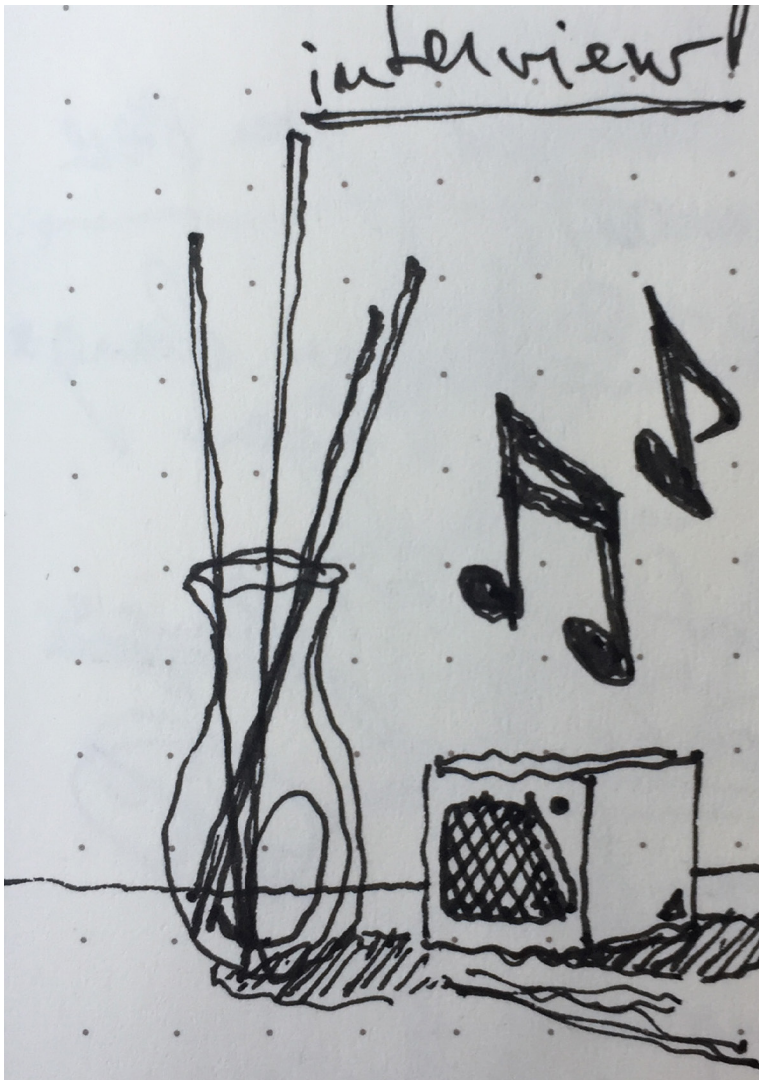
EXPANDABLE



Cruxes, Comfort, and Value

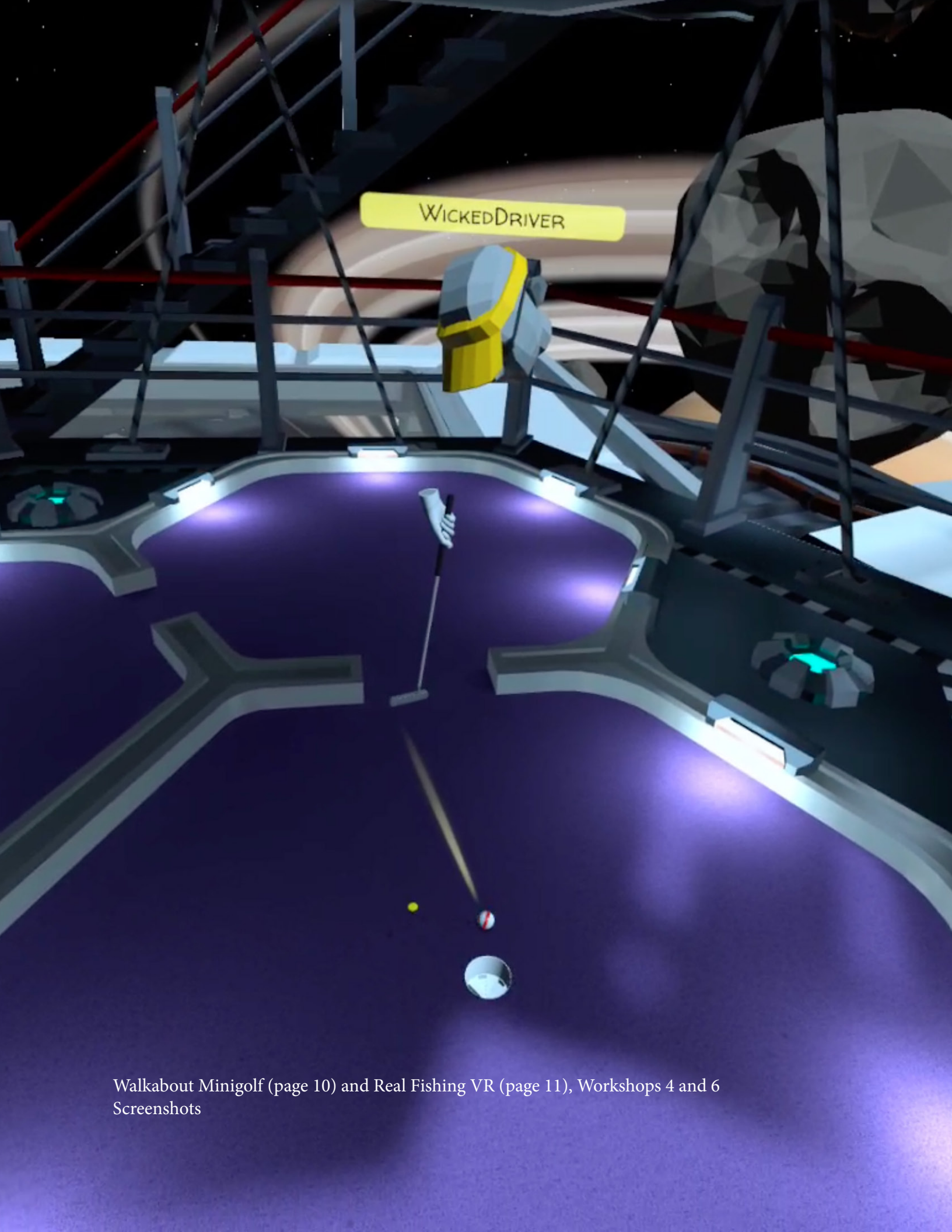
“By putting more obstacles, you help me,” says Peace and Development student Lumi Hultkrantz during the post-workshop interview. Together we sculpted our context. We decided that the crux was our comfort, so the Stick had to be moved without us leaving the couch. Now, let us see the idiot in action!

- We scanned the reachable area of any Stick-quality object.
- We questioned things made of wood, such as paper and furniture.
- We questioned seemingly unrelated things, such as light and the human body, to uncover the boundaries of the experiment.
- We saw incense stick on an unreachable table from the room.
- We saw the speaker on the same table.
- We figured that we could move the unreachable incense stick through sound vibrations from the nearby speaker, the most effective being a low frequency.
- We moved the Stick with a song.
- Yay?



There it was; we did it. Only to find out the little value it had. Sure, this anticlimatic victory meant a piece of the puzzle, realizing the importance of value. And since value struck my interest, it was meant to be read-dressed. How can we have value in our designs if we only move sticks? The Stick-Moving workshop underwhelmed Hultkrantz by showing no direct impact on life quality. Value comes in many shapes and supports the essence of change. The Stick's repositioning has to defend an idea of progress or hope to show its worth. I will continue on that topic in one of the following paragraphs.

Georgian Turturica
Incense sticks and speaker, Workshop 2
Sketch



Walkabout Minigolf (page 10) and Real Fishing VR (page 11), Workshops 4 and 6 Screenshots

Artistic Approach

Fine Art alumni Andra Manafu and I met in virtual reality to play mini-golf and discuss the value of moving a Stick. I tried to be transparent about the relationship between our workshop, the previous ones, and probably the following. I familiarized her participation influence and her ability to pause or terminate the workshop at any point. Afterward, we had solid ground to explore together. Deliyka's idea to make use of an ambient environment came in handy. The first workshop was rather loose, mainly dedicated to enforcing the participant without expecting much early.

The second workshop took place on a VR shore. There we fished and slowly transferred our design thinking into an artistic one. Maybe at first, Manafu did not have the agency to pull me into her realm, yet after she became accustomed to the Stick, the interaction converted. "Who is the Stick?" asked Manafu. Before that I had not questioned the possibility of the Stick's subjectivity. She later articulated that romanticization is often frowned upon, being judged as an irrational or infantile perspective. She made me question my stiff paradigm. Maybe we did not move a Stick, but we reshaped the area. The Stick can now move elsewhere. We started depicting the creative direction of this project. Coming back to thinking with Tony Fry about the self-reflexive aspect of participatory design, the workshop we executed became as well self-reflective.





Andrei Zota, Georgian Turturica, Serban Bila, Andra Manafu, Elvis Dumitru, Ionut Cristache
 Brainstorming of what the Stick we are about to move should look like, Workshop 7
 Miro

Rituals and Value

While having a cup of tea in the morning, I watched a magpie building a nest in the tree found in front of my kitchen window. I admired the motivation of this bird to move several Sticks. Suddenly, the magpie accidentally dropped a Stick. Having in mind the idea of romanticizing the Stick, I went out to collect it. It was the Stick. I could not explain why, but I knew it. I want to explain why so I can support my design decision. I was in negation. “This is not a design decision,” I was telling myself. Maybe it does not have to be. I kept the Stick and waited for an opportunity to present it. Here I decided to trust my intuition regarding the nest fallen Stick. This Stick made its way to my attention. The Stick seemed uninteresting to the magpie as it collected several others afterward. The magpie left it behind, while other ecosystem members could interact with it freely. This kleptomaniac life form that took the opportunity is me, the designer. (or just me, we are yet to find out)

Manafu joined me again, this time on Miro, alongside four other close friends. We started by defining a shared understanding of a stick, yet again. The Stick I collected the other day was just as described. Together we agreed that the first move we make with the Stick is me bringing and displaying it, the stick vernissage, as we called it. Afterward, we finally thought about creating a ritual around the Stick to add value to it.

I was enrolled as the stick guardian and prescribed to take care of it, as the Stick became a friendship amulet. The Stick is displayed to the friend group to mark its safety. The Stick in itself has value now, contrary to the previously mentioned theory supporting that the Stick's replacement is the one to carry the change value. It may come as an exception that proves the rule since the Stick does not hold value separately from the context of displaying it and confirming its safety. The Stick has value because that particular Stick is the one to be moved and not any other Stick.

The Stick guardian's responsibility to ensure the Stick's safety can be seen as the designer's obligation to avoid corruption. It may seem farfetched, but allow me to support my idea. Coming back to Monteiro's emphasis on the designer's oath scarcity, I claim to protect my cause as Stick guardian. Now that the Stick has value, this value could also be contested or traded. Would I trade the Stick's safety for something that I also find valuable? What sort of effect would that have on the stakeholders? (my friends) Am I responsible for informing and consulting them regarding such decisions?

Conclusive Workshops

The exploration phase of this thesis has helped me unveil the theory behind the project, the reachable fertile ground where I could plant the idea seed. Each of these first eight experimental workshops has shown me what is more or less possible. After acquiring knowledge regarding the suitable environment, I must also decide where to plant the seed. Here I come with three different patches of soil that might nurture the seed into thriving.

Design and Posthumanism

The first patch of soil to plant the seed idea is Design and Posthumanism, a Swedish design network that encourages the merge of design practice, education, and research with how Design impacts animals, plants, and everything in-between or beyond. I consider that such a mindful network of designers would adopt the Idiot as a valuable exploration method. Not only could they unpick the workshop's potential due to their expertise, but counsel me on forward development.

What I hoped to accomplish is a changing experience. An experience that brings the participant's values together and defines the very personal motivation behind the formation of this network. The common ground is already vividly articulated: Design and posthumanism. What stands in the shade? What systems pushed them towards these fields? What question is too stupid to be voiced and why? Is it just as ridiculous for every member of the network? I believe that putting the absurd in the spotlight may help us learn more about what we reckon as wise.

Here the Stick comes into the frame. How can we see the Stick from a posthumanist perspective? Does the Stick fit within a posthumanist design approach? If so, why? If not, why not?

The workshop has hosted two participants, Embedded Design Master student Agnieszka Madej and Fine Arts Master student Yana Deliyska, who engaged in moving the Stick from a posthumanism perspective. The framework included a short presentation of our backgrounds and motivation within the design industry, an introduction to the Idiot Manifesto and the Stick, followed by a try-out where all three of us took the Idiot's responsibility to ask explorative questions. Next, they upgraded and edited the manifesto. Some of these edits refer to phrasing, while a more developed difference is seen in how they see the Idiot's character. I consider that the experience of being the Idiot gave them the proper perspective to elaborate on the persona.

After that, we tried one more round of questions, and lastly, they were asked to voice their emotional experience and bring critique and feedback. We questioned our perspective towards the Stick, posthumanist or anthropocentric. We discussed its living condition, memory, logic, how to ask the Stick for consent, who already has permission to move the Stick and cares for it, who the Stick cares back for, its culture, the forest's culture, its essence, its subjectivity or objectivity, its common sense or horse sense, and its similarities to the Idiot.

When it comes to the Idiot's intention to generate change, Madej commented that the Idiot does not necessarily seek good or bad change. At the same time, Deliyska added that the change is a byproduct of being slowed down and lost. Madej compares the exchange of the Idiot's role to the relay race. While Deliyska, having the experience of the first Stick-Moving workshop, observes an evolution emerging with the posthumanist context addition. This evolution is defined by addressing a specific context. Even though, in the beginning, I avoided having a context to collect assumptions, at this point in this workshop the context proved to be more generative.

Nevertheless, the context did not stop us from exploring our understanding of it before taking any decision. Since only the three of us were present, the participants mentioned that my sober approach seemed sufficient to keep the speculation going. Still, they advised me to invite more facilitators in a more numerous participation rate case.

Addressing Stick-Moving through a posthumanist lens, we have explored Stick's relation within one general environment: the forest. We do not only move a Stick, but we investigate its linkage with flora and fauna breeding it. Displacing or replacing the Stick from an ecological perspective obliges us to observe and question more than the Stick itself. Moving a Stick within a highly bird-populated area conveys several new questions regarding the birds' reactions to our measures. Allow me yet another frivolous stick-irony: our benchmarks keep branching out.

Friendship Workshop

The second patch of soil is a conclusive informal workshop with some friends that helped me during the explorative part of the project. Together we reached the idea of forming a ritual where the Stick is charged with emotional value and symbolizes our relationship. Since they became familiar with both the Stick and the Idiot, we could now switch roles and define the ritual in better detail. Each of us could play the Idiot and thus balance the creative input. We could take turns in guiding each other in the dark. We could find one question more absurd than before and build a pyramid of ambiguity that may uncover our creativity and values. The participatory design workshop could become a bonding exercise as well as it is a design project. Like the previous workshop sports the posthumanist lens, this one involves the friendship and rituals topics. A workshop hosting a friend circle would emphasize the obvious asset, friendship, yet it is still satisfactory to come to this conclusion together. Now the questions arise from this double diamond middle knot, friendship rituals.

The Stick is cared for by a bunch of Idiots willing to define its value. The Idiot method welcomed and performed adequately for determining a clear picture of our contextual values that the Stick could inherit. For example, we valued friendship and portrayed its safety by directing it to the Stick's safety. In that case, we could label this reinforcement of the physical Stick as an example of non-consumeristic product design. The Stick in its physical form was found and collected, but the meaning behind the amulet Stick was designed with the Idiot method.

Vrångsholmen Art Residence

The third patch of soil is the Vrångsholmen art residence, where ten creatives gather to participate in each other's workshop. This type of flat hierarchy and common interest would be efficient for collecting genuine feedback. We would learn about the practice and its methodology through the active intake. We would understand how different practitioners structure and perform their workshops in a specifically attributed environment. Also, the dedicated space would aid us with time to reflect and comment on our work. Compared to the previous two examples, the formal Design and Posthumanism workshop and the informal ritual workshop, the Vrångsholmen residence would enable not only one seed in its soil, but it would rather be a garden that facilitates several idea plants. If you allow me one more metaphor regarding farming, I would fetch the concept of pollination and the prospect to convey each other's qualities.

Unfortunately, my application was not selected for the residence. On the other hand, the previously mentioned participant, Yana Deliyska, was admitted to the art residence with her application. Deliyska works with her own theory of the Idiot, which is not a design method but a fine arts element. We often discussed these similarly named characters and the differences between my Idiot and her Idiot. Since she will partake at Vrångsholmen art residence, we will try to find supporting segments from my project that could assist hers. Or, otherwise, components that highlight the opposition and its reasoning.

+Change Aspect

This thesis consists of my experience within the Design +Change program as a collection of designerly curated insights and my response to what can be assumed as a positive change. I have a brief background in product design education, and Design +Change has enrolled me in the process of a drastic paradigm shift. I have been slowly furthering myself from materiality due to consistently questioning my intentions within the design industry. The program enabled me to explore before taking action. It boosted me to arrive closer to the core of my practice. I contradict myself on what I had the most confidence in, often to the point where I would think there was no meaning behind my method, but ultimately polishing my motivation into sharper value awareness. Since I opt for a positive change, I must formulate my core values. I must focus on what drives me and bridge it over participants to keep myself grounded. Even when I think I know that my goal has value, I must also find its place within the design net. I do not work alone; I collaborate locally with participants but with design scholars, citizens, and the environment in a broader sense. I must apprehend my agency and serve to make the most out of my current position in the industry.

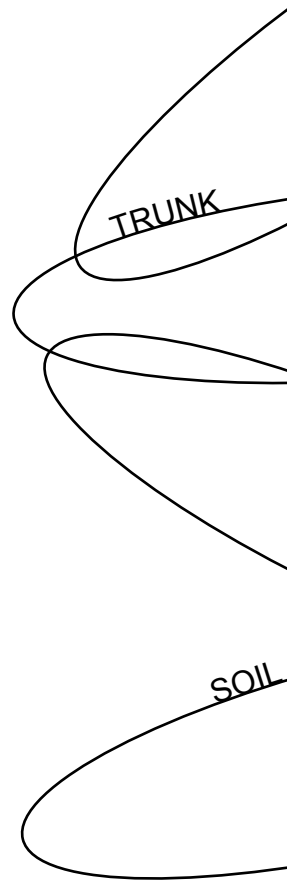
My approach is frequently abstract in the beginning since I start by assuming that my means are not yet defined. Yet, I doubt Design is often linear. So, if questioning touched me the most throughout my Bachelor's education, it is also questioning that I value as a moral agency to give back to the design world. The Idiot method is my input. I do not have the vital expertise to analyze the complexity of an already developing project, but through the Idiot, I can help others strand from obviousness. Many practitioners can adopt the Idiot character, not necessarily in an unguided manner, but quite the opposite. The Idiot can be channeled towards specific details and process milestones. Even though the Idiot may ask stupid questions, the intention of the Idiot is not unfounded. The method can be utilized when a designer or design team needs more roundness in determination. It can play a virtual role in creative blocks as a strategy of looking the opposite way from constructing, balancing the structure and enhancing the qualities. Talking about balancing, let me ask, in the voice of the Idiot: can we be confident in the correct answer if we cannot convey the wrong answer?

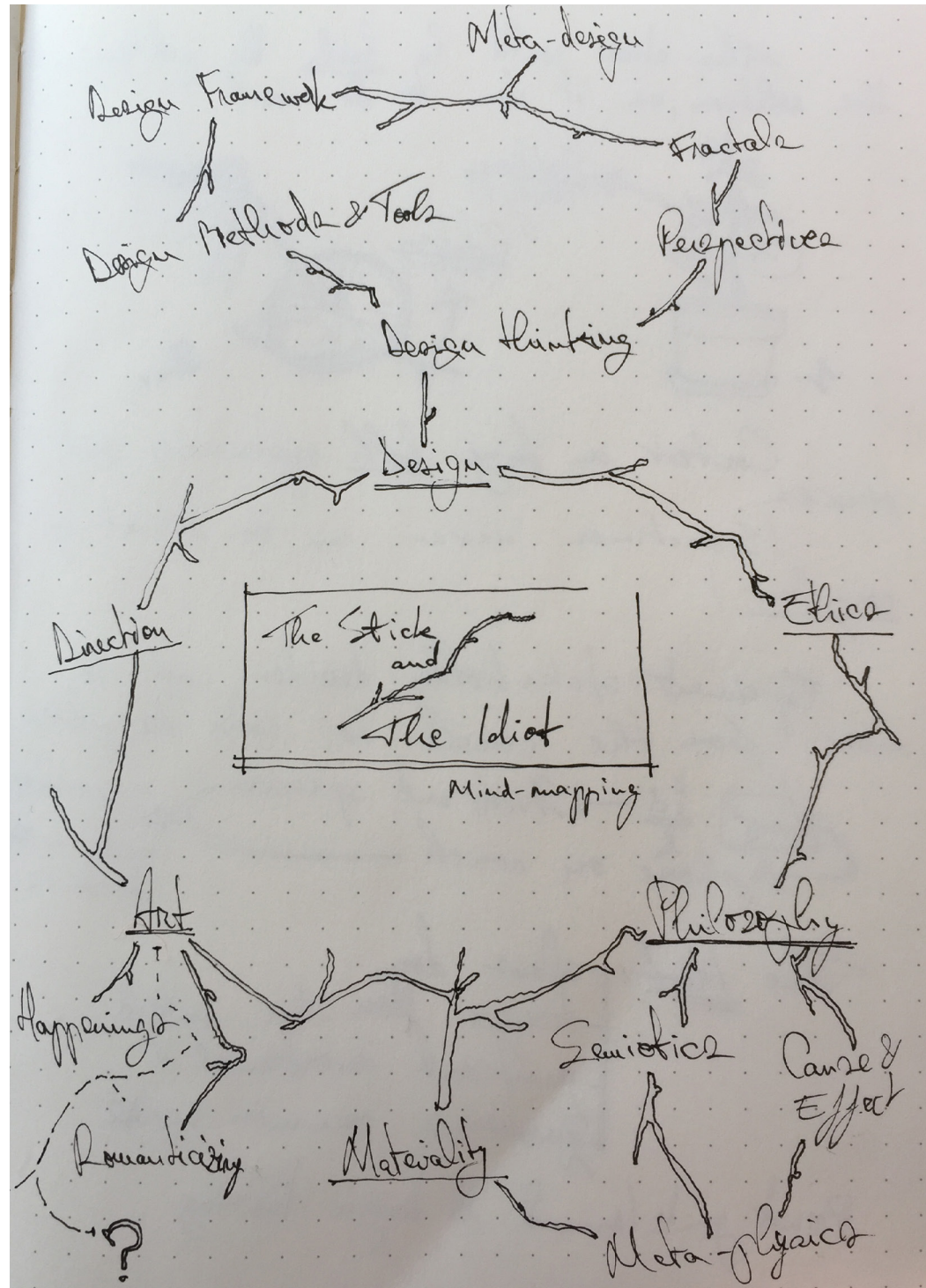
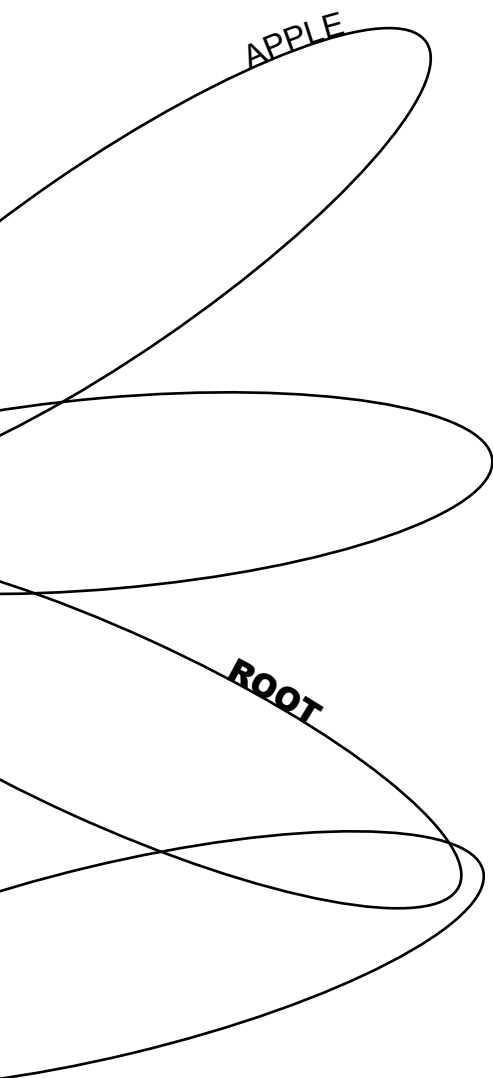
Metadesign and Sustainability

Yes, the previous examples are local successes and do not relate much to society. But, the workshop structure can be advanced and open source. The balance between ethics, materiality and creative direction could be sported in influential environments. We developed a somewhat satisfactory local design solution through a couple of open workshops and a dummy-problem. The next step is to collect the insights articulated above and generate a more robust, rigid, and effective workshop strategy. I shape this framework for the sake of ethical Design. Once the framework is standing, the dummy-problem can be excluded. The framework is meant to bring all four spheres of sustainability closer and help designers avoid overlooking one aspect for the other. Designers are my target audience.

Thinking with Alice Rawsthorn, I try to address the problem from the root. Actually, why not question the soil as well? Or the tree and the fruit? Let us make space for the three levels of metadesign from designers Mathilda Tham, Åsa Ståhl, and Sara Hyltén-Cavallius. (Oikology - Home Ecologics, 2019) They draw a linear connection between the local and global levels, which defines the context of a design project. I would like to reinterpret this theory through my example from before. We can start by renaming the product from the local level as “an apple,” one particular apple. Secondly, the system can be renamed “the tree” on which branch the previously mentioned apple grew. While the paradigm, the third level, is “the soil” in which the tree has matured roots. The roots are part of the tree, just as the above-ground trunk and branches. Therefore, the root system is surrounded by the soil, which is the paradigm. Here I try to stress the significance of the root since it is our gateway to investigating the rest of the system and the soil. The root is less tangible, considering the effort and strategy behind the procedure. It may be a slower process than examining the above-ground system, but it may give us more authentic leverage.

As I mentioned before, I hope for designers to examine how our paradigm is designed. Once we understand our prejudices and assumptions, we can be mindful of our cognitive limits.





Georgian Turturica
 Ethics, Materiality, and Creative Direction
 Mapping regarding the initial three columns I had in mind developing
 the workshop structure

Context Lens

In the beginning, the framework of the workshop lacked context, which aided us in probing quick assumptions. Moreover, the lack of context permitted us to stray from any conclusions. Now, contexts such as posthumanism or friendship rituals not only wash off some confusion but encourage participants' agency. One Idiot is bearable and productive, as I try to articulate. The circulation of the Idiot's character is supposedly more expressive since it fetches a variety of Idiot voices. One Idiot inspires the next to dive into one's topic shade. Wandering alongside one other Idiot at a time helps us explore and define our shared understanding of the context, while having one particular Idiot may mostly be effective for exploration only.

In conclusion, welcoming questions that address the value of positive change generates positive change. These questions must help designers explore their paradigm concerning the problem before making design decisions only based on theory and context. The Idiot method fulfills the means of exploration relevant for defining the dynamics and assumptions within the design team. At the same time, the Stick-Moving workshop plays the most ambiguous dummy-problem, both for the Idiot and the rest of the group. If the designers can withstand the Idiot's questions regarding the Stick, they may manage to uncover other grey areas of their design process. Parts that have not been formulated before will arise and potentially frustrate the designers. Yet, the Stick-Moving workshop works as a laboratory that allows exploration free of danger, in contrast with more relevant design issues.

The Stick-Moving dummy-problem workshop creates a safe space for exploration and reflection that could benefit the positive growth of design teams dynamics, intentions and assumptions in the design industry.

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